Gandhara–Nagara, differentiating it from parallel eastern developments in northern and southern India.[25]

In arguing for the distinction of the Gandhara–Nagara school of temple architecture, Meister identified its three fundamental sources, which were a convergence of indigenous and imported conventions. Straddling both categories was the Buddhist architecture and iconography (*c.* 100 BCE–500 CE) of historical Gandhara, which encompassed localized interpretations and applications of Greco-Roman forms and iconographies. These Buddhist remains spanned northwest Pakistan through eastern Afghanistan, largely the area where Gandhara–Nagara temples are found. The influx of north Indian Nagara forms (fifth–seventh centuries CE) was equally evident, though locally interpreted based on the available building materials and also distinctive rituals (see below). Finally, elements from the temple architecture of Kashmir were also traceable in the regional temples' architectural fabric.[26] Although no architectural treatises codifying the Gandhara–Nagara school have yet been found, Meister's comprehensive analyses of the surviving buildings have elucidated the developments in the regional style's forms and iconographies over time: decorative elements deriving from the Hellenistic past of the area, for example, continued to play important iconographic roles in Gandhara–Nagara decoration (Figure 6.4). Additionally, the distinctive and ubiquitous trefoil arch, possibly deriving from Kashmiri architectural forms, was also a characteristic feature of Gandhara–Nagara temples (Figures 6.4–6.6).[27]



Figure 6.3 *Rajagira Mosque, Udegram,* mihrab. *© Photograph Alka Patel 1997.*

The surviving temple complexes provide invaluable insights, including possibly new functions and rituals that distinguished them from their eastern counterparts. Unlike the north Indian examples, Gandhara–Nagara temples were constructed of the local volcanic stone (*kanjur*) hewn into blocks, permitting multi-storied interiors (Figure 6.6). The upper stories were usually single chambers, roofed with domes resting on stepped squinches (Figure 6.7). Access to the upper floors was provided by dark, narrow inclined corridors that were dimly illuminated and ventilated by